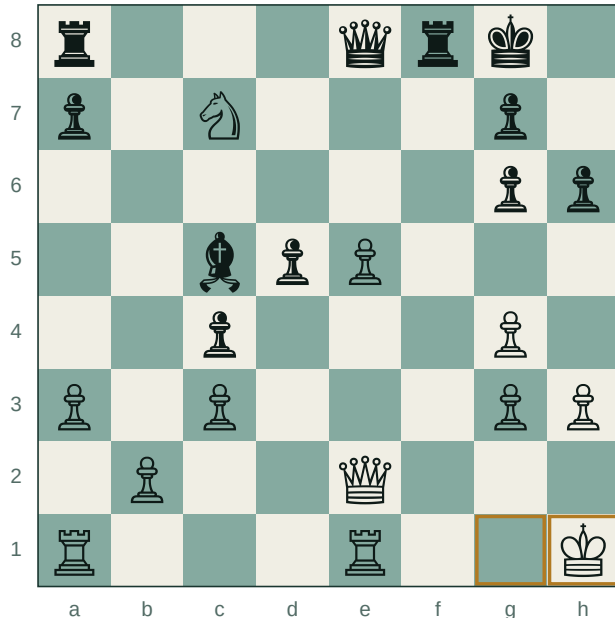


Calculated sacrifices: Black, move 25

Calculated sacrifices

Black to move



Previous move: 25.Kh1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

25...Qc6 26. Nxa8 Rf2

25...Qc6 The queen moves from e8 to c6. Recorded reply: **26.Nxa8**.

26...Rf2 The rook moves from f8 to f2.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 23 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by -5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -5: the balance goes from -1 to -6. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attractive attacking picture is not compensation by itself. Continue until the resulting position can be evaluated honestly.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A sacrifice exchanges material for a concrete benefit. The benefit may be mate, a stronger attack, a recovered investment, or lasting activity; it must be shown through moves.

HOW TO LOOK

State what the sacrifice changes: a defender, a line, a king square, or a critical tempo. Calculate acceptance and plausible refusal.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: knight on c7. Check for tactical protection.